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# Hebrew Bible / Old Testament The History of Its Interpretation

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From the Beginnings to the Middle Ages  
(Until 1300)

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In this context, it bears remembering that the Judaism which emerged from the medieval melting pot was not monolithic – hardly so in a community which could burn the writings of Maimonides and, shortly thereafter, so enthusiastically place much of its confidence in a figure like Shabbatai Zvi, or even his predecessor Isaac Luria. Nonetheless, at least one of the strains of Judaism which flowered during this period used philology as an exegetical tool to achieve a straightforward treatment of Scripture.

To be sure, this approach would in time be submerged by the rising power of Kabbalah, the emergence of non-intellectual approaches to Judaism in parts of Eastern Europe, the despair which followed the Inquisition, and a turn to the Talmud as the main locus for Jewish study.<sup>36</sup> But it did not die. On the one hand, it was transmitted to the Christian world, where a resurgence of interest in the Bible was underway, nourished by the forces unleashed by the Renaissance and the Reformation.<sup>37</sup> This movement honored Antiquity and elevated the Bible which, it was thought, any plowboy could understand.

Many of the figures involved in these movements had studied the Bible with Jews such as Elijah Levita and Obadiah Sforno, who provided a conduit for the methods and conclusions of their earlier co-religionists into the Protestant-inspired development of modern biblical studies during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries.<sup>38</sup> At the same time, commitment to the *peshat* lay largely dormant within the Jewish community, which directed much of its attention to rabbinic texts. However, Jewish biblical scholarship would rise again in the nineteenth and, especially, the twentieth centuries, when a resurgence of interest in the Bible in both America and Israel gave rise to a generation of Jewish scholars wedded to history and philology. That this occurred in a benign and pluralistic setting, where Jewish tradition had come to be cherished in a culture that was both curious about the Bible and respectful of Jews' closeness to it, need not be accidental. Nor is the rise of a new generation of Jews who proudly sought to reclaim a tradition they could trace back for centuries.<sup>39</sup> Still, however much this development is a product of modern circumstances, it nonetheless marks the reemergence of a tendency with deep roots in the Jewish tradition, a return to reading Scripture naturally and to focusing on its straightforward meaning.

See F. E. GREENSPAHN, "How Modern are Modern Biblical Studies?", *Minhah le-Nahum. Biblical and Other Studies Presented to Nahum M. Sarna in Honor of his Seventieth Birthday* (ed. M. Brettler / M. Fishbane; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press 1993) 168, n. 1.

<sup>36</sup> F. TALMAGE, "Keep Your Sons From Scripture: The Bible in Medieval Jewish Scholarship and Spirituality", *Understanding Scripture. Explorations of Jewish and Christian Traditions of Interpretation* (ed. C. Thoma / M. Wyschogrod; Mahwah, NJ: Paulist Press 1987) 84–85.

<sup>37</sup> Cf. J. FRIEDMAN, *The Most Ancient Testimony. Sixteenth Century Christian-Hebraica in the Age of Renaissance Nostalgia* (Athens, OH: Ohio UP 1983).

<sup>38</sup> Cf. J. L. KUGEL, "Biblical Studies and Jewish Studies", *Association for Jewish Studies Newsletter* 36 (1986) 22–23; J. D. LEVENSON, "The Hebrew Bible, the Old Testament, and Historical Criticism", *The Future of Biblical Studies: The Hebrew Scriptures* (ed. R. E. Friedman / H. G. M. Williamson; Decatur, GA: Scholars Press 1987) 28–47.

<sup>39</sup> Cf. S. D. SPERLING, *Students of the Covenant. A History of Jewish Biblical Scholarship in North America* (Atlanta: Scholars Press 1952) 115–35.

## 25.2. The Interpretative Value of the Massoretic Punctuation

By E.J. REVELL, Toronto

*Sources: The Old Testament Diligently Revised according to the Massorah and the Early Editions with the Various Readings from MSS and the Ancient Versions* by C. D. GINSBURG (London: British and Foreign Bible Society 1926; repr. as: גינצבורג כ. ד. ירושלים: [מקור 1970]; G. E. WEIL, P. RIVIÈRE et M. SERFATY, *Concordance de la cantilation du pentateuque et des cinq megillot* (Documentation de la Bible 1; Paris: Éditions du C. N. R. S. 1978); idem, *Concordance de la cantilation des premiers prophètes: Josué, Juges, Samuel, et Rois* (Documentation de la Bible 2; Paris: Éditions du C. N. R. S. 1982).

Early sources describing the accents are referred to in Dotan, Vocalisation and Accentuation, and Yeivin, Introduction; their use by the commentators is surveyed in Ackermann, Das hermeneutische Element, and Kogut, מעימים לפרשנות as listed below.

*General works:* A. ACKERMANN, *Das hermeneutische Element der biblischen Accentuation* (Berlin: S. Calvary 1893); I. ADLER, "Histoire de la musique religieuse juive", *Encyclopédie des musiques sacrées* (Paris: Editions Labergerie 1968) I, 469–93; M. ARONOFF, "Orthography and Linguistic Theory: The Syntactic Basis of the Masoretic Hebrew Punctuation", *Language* 61 (1985) 28–72; S. AVINUN, *אספקטים תחביריים, לוגיים וסמנטיים של חלוקת פסוקים לפי טעמי המקרא*, *Leshonenu* 53 (1988/89) 157–92; M. BREUER, [1958] *ההסתדרות הציונית* [ירושלים: שבמקרא 1977]; idem, [1982] *טעמי המקרא בכ"א ספרים ובספרי אמ"ת* [ירושלים: הוצאת מכללה 1982]; idem, *כתר*, *הביצוע*, *אדם צובה* *הנוסח המקובל של המקרא* [ירושלים: מוסד הרב קוק 1977]; idem, *המקור של טעמי המקרא הטברניים: מחקר בגישה דוקטרינית על סמך חוקים בסיסיים בביצוע קולית* *ספר ידוקי הטעמים לר' אהרן*, *D. COHEN / D. WEIL*, *התפקיד התחבירי*, *Leshonenu* 53 (1988/89) 7–30; A. DOTAN, [1967] *האקדמיה ללשון העברית*, *Section 5 of his art. 'Masorah'* *EJ* 16 (1971) 1433–71, bibliography 1481–82; B. E. DRESHER, "The Prosodic Basis of the Tiberian Hebrew System of Accents", *Language* 70 (1994) 1–52; I. ELДАР, *תורת הקריאה במקרא*, *Tarbiz* 54 (1985) 225–43; A. HERZOG, "Masoretic Accents (Musical Rendition)", *EJ* 11 (1971) 1098–1111; S. KOGUT, *בהינתן לשונות*, *ועניינים של זיקות ומחלוקות בין פרשנות הטעמים לפרשנות המסורתית* [ירושלים: מאגנס 1994]; M. LAVIAN, [1978–1985] *טעמים ומשמעותם במקרא* [ירושלים: דפוס א.ב. 1978–1985]; S. J. LIEBERMAN, "Towards a Graphemics of the Tiberian Bible", *Linguistics and Biblical Hebrew* (ed. W. R. Bodine; Winona Lake: Eisenbrauns 1992) 255–78; E. J. REVELL, *Biblical Texts with Palestinian Pointing and their Accents* (Masoretic Studies 4; Missoula: Scholars Press 1977); E. SHERESHEVSKI, "The Accents in Rashi's Commentary" *JQR* 62 (1971/72) 277–87; D. M. WEIL, *The Masoretic Chant of the Bible* (Jerusalem: Rubin Mass 1995); W. WICKES, *A Treatise on the Accentuation of the Three so-called Poetical Books of the Old Testament, Psalms, Proverbs, and Job* (Oxford: Clarendon Press 1881); idem, *A Treatise on the Accentuation of the Twenty-One so-called Prose Books of the Old Testament* (Oxford: Clarendon Press 1887); idem, *Two Treatises on the Accentuation of the Old Testament* [The above two works reprinted, with a prolegomenon by A. Dotan] (New York: KTAV 1970); I. YEIVIN, [1976] *מבוא למסורה הטברנית* [ירושלים: אקדמון 1976]; idem, *Introduction to the Tiberian Masorah* [A translation of the above with additions] (Masoretic Studies 5; Missoula: Scholars Press 1980); idem, *כתר אדם צובה*, *ניקודו וטעמיו* [כתבי מפעל המקרא של האוניברסיטה העברית ג'; ירושלים: מאגנס 1969].

The term ‘Massoretic punctuation’ refers to the signs commonly called ‘accents’ in English, which are used in codices and printed texts of the Hebrew Bible.

The use of these signs is based on the verses, the short units into which the biblical text is divided. In grammatical terms, a verse may consist of a single clause, of several clauses, or it may consist of a part of a clause, as is the case with the three-word verses into which the list of names in Neh 10:3-8 is divided. The verse division is conditioned in a general way by syntax, but also by content, longer verses being characteristic of narrative passages, where the language is relatively easy to understand, and its message relatively unimportant. A systematic study of the basis of the verse division, however, has yet to be made.

Units similar to the biblical verses are marked in a few ancient texts. The example closest to biblical Hebrew is that of the inscription of Mesha, King of Moab (mentioned in 2 Kgs 3:4). Possibly, then, the verse division may reflect some feature characteristic of public reading or speech in the language of ancient Israel and the surrounding nations. The traditional division of poetic passages is reflected in the earliest known manuscripts of the Septuagint, and in the Hebrew manuscripts from Qumran. Verse-like divisions in prose passages are marked in one or two early manuscripts of the Greek translation, but this is not usual; the marking of such divisions in Hebrew texts became customary only with the development of the accent signs.<sup>1</sup>

Before the marking of verse divisions in texts was customary, these divisions were maintained orally in the reading tradition. They are recognized in some passages of the Talmud, such as those dealing with the way the text is to be read in the synagogue. The Greek translation shows a certain amount of difference from the verse division of the received Hebrew text, but this feature has not been studied. Differences within the Hebrew tradition are reflected in the phenomenon known as *pisqah be'emša' pasuq*.<sup>2</sup> Talmudic comments also occasionally reflect differences from the received division. Manuscripts which mark verse divisions show that, from the ninth century on, the tradition is fixed; any variation from the received verse division is most probably accidental.

The accents subdivide the verses. Subdivisions of the same sort are marked in the earliest known Septuagint manuscript, but the accent signs themselves are known only from the Hebrew codices of the ninth century and later.<sup>3</sup> Sys-

<sup>1</sup> The divisions in the inscription of Mesha text are described in A. NACCACCI, "The Stele of Mesha and the Bible", *Orientalia* 63 (1994) 226-48, at pp. 231-36. Information on the divisions marked in Greek prose texts is given by E. Tov, in: *The Greek Minor Prophets Scroll from Nahal Hever* (DJD VIII; Oxford: Clarendon 1990) 9-12. For the division of poetic passages, see Deuteronomy 32 in F. DUNAND, *Papyrus grecs bibliques* (*Papyrus F. Inv.* 266) (Le Caire: Imprimerie de l'Institut Français d'archéologie orientale 1966), and in 4QpalaeoDeut'.

<sup>2</sup> A paragraph division within a verse. Some Qumran MSS which show paragraphing generally consistent with the massoretic *pisqot*, as 4QpalaeoExod<sup>m</sup>, occasionally mark such a division within a massoretic verse. *Pisqot* are described in Yeivin, Introduction (1980) #74-5; for a full study see J. M. OESCH, *Petucha und Setuma: Untersuchungen zu einer überlieferten Gliederung im hebräischen Text des Alten Testaments* (OBO 27; Freiburg: Universitätsverlag / Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht 1979). The significance of the phenomenon of *Pisqah be'emša' pasuq* is discussed by R. KASHER, 'פיסקא באמצע פסוק' בזיקתה לחלוקת המקרא לפסוקים לאור כתבי-יד עבריים לספר שמואל, *Textus XII* (1985) לב-נה.

<sup>3</sup> The interrelation of accents and *sheva* vowels suggests that the MT accent system was already in use quite early in the first millennium. See A. DOTAN, מערכת הטעמים של תולדות התהוותה של מערכת הטעמים, *לחלוקת התהוותה של מערכת הטעמים*.

tems of marking vowels and accents arose independently in different parts of the Jewish world; three systems of signs are recognized (each of which shows some variant forms), called the Tiberian (that of the received text), the Babylonian and the Palestinian. The Babylonian system differs from the Tiberian to some extent in the way the verse is subdivided. The Palestinian system is less precisely marked than the Tiberian, but rarely conflicts with it in more than minor matters, and so seems to represent the same basic tradition.<sup>4</sup> Variations within the Tiberian system persisted until the text was printed, but can scarcely ever be said to be of any significance for interpretation. The Tiberian accentuation of the three 'poetical books' (Psalms, Proverbs, and Job) differs from that used in the rest of the text (the '21 books').<sup>5</sup> This survey is concerned with the Tiberian system used in the 21 books, which is described in the works of M. BREUER, W. WICKES, and I. YEIVIN listed in the Bibliography.

In medieval texts, the accents are designated by words referring to melody, as Arabic *lahn*, Hebrew נגינה, or to meaning, as Hebrew טעם, as in the treatise of the famous massorete Aharon ben Mosheh ben Asher (Dotan, ספר דקדוקי ספר הטעמים 1967). Terms of both types are used in the Talmud (*b. Meg.* 3a, 32a), but the precise referents of the words in question are uncertain. ELAN DRESHER argues persuasively that the system of accents originated in a transcription of the prosodic patterns of the traditional liturgical reading (Prosodic Basis, 1994). However, there is no doubt that the chants used in medieval and later times had ancient roots; melodies were no doubt used from early times to give prominence to significant prosodic features. The basic purpose of the liturgical reading was to present the text to the congregation in a way that enhanced their understanding of it. WEIL finds, through his reconstruction, that musical and logico-syntactical features were harmoniously integrated through the original performance (Masoretic Chant, 1995, 291). The units into which the text was divided by the prosodico-musical patterns were units of sense; the accent signs which represent these patterns can be understood as punctuation.<sup>6</sup> The following survey is concerned with this aspect of the signs.

In the Tiberian tradition represented in the received text, each word is marked with an accent, or with the hyphen-like *maqfef*.<sup>7</sup> Accents are of two types: conjunctive, showing that the word so marked is joined to what follows,

[מחקרים בלשון ב-ג], (1987) 355-63. The system of performance represented must date from the second Temple period according to Weil, *Masoretic Chant*, 301-18. For the use of spaces in a Greek text corresponding closely to the massoretic disjunctives, see E.J. REVELL, "The Oldest Evidence for the Hebrew Accent System", *BJRL* 54 (1971/72) 214-22.

<sup>4</sup> The Babylonian system is described in A. SPANIER, *Die massoretischen Akzente: Eine Darlegung des Systems nebst Beiträgen zum Verständnis ihrer Entwicklung* (Berlin: Akademie Verlag 1927), the Palestinian in Revell, *Biblical Texts* (1977).

<sup>5</sup> The signs used in 'the 3 books', and the details of their use, differ from those in 'the 21' to some extent, but the general principles of use are the same. The same is true of the Palestinian system, but not of the Babylonian.

<sup>6</sup> Thus DRESHER finds it almost unnecessary to consider music as affecting the deployment of the signs (Prosodic Basis, 1994, 47-48), as do other scholars mainly concerned with their syntactic value, as J.D. PRICE, *The Syntax of the Masoretic Accents in the Hebrew Bible* (Lewiston: E. Mellen 1990) 13-15. On musical aspects of the accentuation generally, see Adler, *Histoire I* (1968), 469-93; Herzog, *Masoretic Accents* (1971).

<sup>7</sup> Words joined with *maqfef* form a unit chanted to the melody represented by the accent on

and disjunctive, showing that it is separated. The different conjunctive accents are generally regarded as equivalent in joining power.<sup>8</sup> They were not marked in the Babylonian system (save in later manuscripts, where the Tiberian signs were used). A set of signs was developed in the Palestinian system, but fewer were used than in the Tiberian, and most Palestinian manuscripts either do not mark conjunctives, or use a single sign corresponding to any Tiberian conjunctive or *maqgef*.

Each disjunctive accent marks the end of a prosodic phrase, which may consist of a single word, or of several joined by conjunctives. The disjunctive accents form a hierarchy, so that the disjunctive chosen to mark each phrase shows the relation of that phrase to those which precede and follow. Thus the accentuation of a verse shows how the words in it relate to each other. The relationship so marked is most easily described as a series of dichotomies: each verse is divided into two parts, each of which is itself divided into two, and so on. The result is similar to the 'immediate constituent' form of analysis used by some linguists, as is shown by the following example (Ruth 1:1):<sup>9</sup>

|       |                     |                                                                                                 |
|-------|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|       |                     | וַיְהִי בַיּוֹם שֶׁשָּׁפַט הַשִּׁפְטִים וַיְהִי רָעָב בָּאֶרֶץ                                  |
|       |                     | וַיֵּלֶךְ אִישׁ מִבֵּית לֶחֶם יְהוּדָה לְגוֹר־בְּשָׂדֵי מוֹאָב הוּא וְאִשְׁתּוֹ וּשְׁנֵי בָנָיו |
| 1     | <i>revia</i>        | It happened                                                                                     |
| 2-3   | <i>pashta-zaqef</i> | in the days of   the judging of the judges                                                      |
| 4-5   | <i>tifha-atnah</i>  | that there was a famine   in the land                                                           |
| 6-7   | <i>geresh-revia</i> | and a man went   from Bethlehem Judah                                                           |
| 8-9   | <i>pashta-zaqef</i> | to stay   in the fields of Moab                                                                 |
| 10-11 | <i>tifha-silluq</i> | he and his wife   and his two sons                                                              |

As this example shows, the punctuational value of each accent is relative, not absolute. Thus in #2-3, the accent *pashta* divides a prepositional phrase; in #8-9, the same accent separates an infinitive from a prepositional modifier, a much more important division in terms of grammar. The punctuational value of an accent depends on its position in the hierarchy, and on the length and structure of the verse over which the hierarchy of accents is deployed. The essential basis for the understanding of the accents as punctuation is, therefore, knowledge of the hierarchy, and this is the concern of the early handbooks, as well as more recent descriptions listed above. The implications of each accent for what is to come form an important aspect of the information provided by adequate knowledge of the hierarchy. A traditional descriptive analysis of the use of the written signs allows only limited possibilities of prediction. Thus *pashta* implies a following *zaqef*, and so a unit of text suitable to carry it, but

the last. Besides its primary accent, a word may bear secondary signs relating to minor details of the chant.

<sup>8</sup> However ACKERMANN states that the first of two successive conjunctives represents the closer relationship, see *Das hermeneutische Element* (1893) 79, #29.

<sup>9</sup> Literal translation is offered to demonstrate the system to those not familiar with Hebrew, but imitation of Hebrew word order is rarely necessary. A vertical line shows that the Hebrew equivalent of the preceding word has a disjunctive. Additional vertical lines denote a higher position in the hierarchy. For treatment of the accentuation as syntactic analysis, see Aronoff, *Orthography and Linguistic Theory* (1985) 28-72; Weil, *Masoretic Chant* (1995) 26-46.

*zaqef* may be followed by another *zaqef* unit, or by *tifha* followed by *atnah* or *silluq*.<sup>10</sup> In *Masoretic Chant*, WEIL restates the traditional description of the system in structuralist terms. He is thereby able to show that the implications of the written signs (and so of the musical tropes they represent) for what is to come are in fact, quite specific.

The example from Ruth 1:1 demonstrates a second important point. The basis for the division of the text by the accents is not grammatical structure. In grammatical terms, the main division in any clause is that between subject and predicate. In #6, however, the subject and the head of the predicate form one of the six accent phrases into which the clause is divided. Ruth 1:3 is composed of two clauses, each made up of a verb followed by a three word subject. The main verse division separates the two clauses, but, in each of those, the first phrase is formed by the verb and the first word of the subject (which is its head).<sup>11</sup> Again, in the second half of Ruth 1:5, the main division separates verb + subject from modifiers of the verb. Divisions marked by major disjunctive accents rarely conflict with syntactic structure in this way, but they are clearly not intended to mark it. The accentuation divides the verse into units of content, just as the verses themselves are units of content, and not grammatically defined. The syntactic structure is not the essence of the content, it is the support used to present it.<sup>12</sup>

The use of the accent signs as indicated above can be described in a series of 'rules'.<sup>13</sup> Two closely related words are typically joined, but, in a group of three, the first has a disjunctive if the third is dependent on the second. Thus in phrases #2-3 in Ruth 1:1 there is a disjunctive on "In the days of", while "the judging of the judges" is treated as a unit to which the preceding word is added, precisely reflecting what was called 'hierarchical structure' in immediate constituent analysis. The same principle accounts for the division of the two subjects in Ruth 1:3: "Elimelek | husband of Naomi" and "She | and her two sons". A phrase separated from the word to which it is most closely related is typically preceded by the strongest disjunctive in the unit, so that *zaqef*, the strongest divider in the clause composed of phrases #6-11 in Ruth 1:1, is used after phrase 9, before the extraposed subject, which is immediately related to "a man" in phrase 6. This arrangement has the effect of presenting the basic structure of the clause as a unit. In addition, it isolates the extraposed subject, treating it as a unit of weight equal to that of the basic clause, and so draws at-

<sup>10</sup> The possibility of prediction on the basis of the written signs is used in the Palestinian 'short-hand' manuscripts, which do not mark those disjunctives which can be securely predicted. See Revell, *Biblical Texts* (1977) 67-74.

<sup>11</sup> Phrases of equal length are thus formed. The subdivision of verses may occasionally have been motivated by a desire to produce units of equal size (see below), but this is certainly not usual.

<sup>12</sup> That is, the first question to be asked of accentuation is not how it relates to syntax, but what is the significance of the division for the presentation of the content, as illustrated by the examples in Breuer, *טעמי המקרא* (1982), chap. 15. It is a mistake to assume that the meaning of a clause must necessarily be presented to those familiar with the language through analysis of its syntax as such.

<sup>13</sup> Ackermann, *Das hermeneutische Element* (1893) 74-82; Yeivin, *Introduction* (1980) #202-206; Breuer, *טעמי המקרא* (1982), chap. 15.

tention to it, as is appropriate for the importance to the narrative of the details which it presents.

It is certainly one of the main purposes of the accentuation to draw attention to significant items in the text. This is achieved by maintaining the unity of, and by isolating, significant groups of words, as just suggested. The particular accents used for the purpose are, in themselves, of no importance. A clear example occurs in Gen 22:10

וישלח אברהם את ידו ויקח את המאכלת לשחט את בנו

"Abraham put out | his hand || and took | the knife ||| to slaughter | his son".

The main division here falls within the second clause, and thus conflicts with the syntactic structure. However, this division presents the description of the action and the statement of its purpose as separate units of content. The words indicating Abraham's dreadful intention are presented in isolation, and so gain the maximum impact. This is an unusually striking example of the common tendency to subordinate introductory clauses to the material they introduce. This is most noticeable in the fact that a clause introducing speech often has a lesser disjunctive than the first unit of the speech it introduces, as in Gen 44:21

ותאמר אל עבדיך הורדהו אלי ואשימה עיני עליו

"And you said | to your servants || bring him down | to me ||| and let me set my eye | on him".

The first clause of the speech is more closely joined to the preceding introductory clause than to what follows. The second clause in the speech, thus isolated, receives greater attention than it would if the main division preceded the first. Joseph's desire to see Benjamin, which is significant in terms of the narrative, is thus given prominence.

The failure to separate an introductory clause sharply from the speech it introduces is usually presented as a feature in which the Hebrew language differed from Greek or English. S. AVINUN shows that a short speech is typically separated from its introduction, as in Gen 44:25

ויאמר אבינו שבו שברו-לנו מעט אכל

"Our father | said || return | buy us a little food".

However, length is not the determining factor. In 1 Chr 14:10

ויאמר לו יהוה עלה ונתתים בידך

"God said to him | 'Go up || and I will give them | into your hand'"

the speech is certainly short, but it is not separated from the introduction, but divided in the usual way, with the effect of drawing attention to the promise in the last clause, as in the speech with similar content in Judg 7:9. Where the main division of the unit follows the introduction, as in Gen 44:25, the possibility of drawing attention to the final clause of the speech is avoided. The buying of food, after all, is not of major interest in the narrative at that point. Similar arguments can be made for the other cases of this type presented by



AVINUN. Other examples in which a division within the speech could easily have been used occur in Gen 3:12; 15:7, 8; 18:3, 17, etc.<sup>14</sup>

The principle that the accents demarcate significant units of content, and refer only indirectly to the syntax used to convey them, can elucidate most questions of accentuation. BREUER notes a number of cases in which a disjunctive dividing a three-word nominal clause separates two words in a construct chain, rather than, as expected, marking the division between subject and predicate, as in *זאת תורת הצרעת* "This is the law | of leprosy" (Lev 14:57).<sup>15</sup> There are eight similar cases with 'law' as head of the construct chain. Related usage can be seen in other structures, as in Lev 7:37; 14:54. BREUER notes similar usage with demonstratives in other contexts, but this, too, is not a reflection of a standard feature of the language. The expected division is shown in *וְזֹאת תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם אֲדֹנֵי יְהוָה* "This | is the law of man || O Lord" (2 Sam 7:19), *זֶאת פֶּתֶחַ-יָם* "This | is the side of the west" (Ezek 47:20), and other examples. The unexpected division presents the crucial information 'This is the law' as a unit, and also draws attention to the following word or words which define the area in which the law applies. It is thus readily intelligible as a presentation of the significant units of content. Where the referents of the words do not require treatment in this way, or are unsuitable for it, such clauses are divided as expected, between subject and predicate.

In the same way, accent variation, such as that recorded in Ginsburg, *The Old Testament Diligently Revised* (1926), typically follows the standard patterns, and represents nothing more than a slight difference of emphasis. For example, the received text divides Gen 37:31

וַיִּקְחוּ אֶת כְּתֹנֶת יוֹסֵף וַיִּשְׁחָטוּ שְׂעִיר עִזִּים וַיִּטְבְּלוּ אֶת הַכְּתֹנֶת בְּדָם

"They took | Joseph's tunic || and they slaughtered | a goat || and they dipped the tunic | in the blood".

The main division logically separates the initial clause from the two interrelated clauses which follow it. A few manuscripts place the main division after 'goat', giving prominence to the dipping of the tunic (with intent to deceive their father). Such variation can be called incorrect, but only in terms of a particular tradition. Where accentuation appears incorrect in more general terms, it is usually the expectation that the accents mark syntax which is at fault.

Because the accentuation is concerned with content, not with structure, it is impossible to provide completely objective guidelines to the understanding of it. Consequently, where the accentuation does not correspond to some translation or interpretation known from ancient sources, any statement on its motivation is necessarily somewhat speculative. However, even where its motiva-

<sup>14</sup> See Avinun, *אספקטים של חלוקת פסוקים* (1989). Where more than one introductory verb is used (as in Gen 14:19), or where a single verb is followed by *לאמר* 'saying' (as Gen 1:22), a major disjunctive usually is used to separate the introduction from the speech. For comments on the separation of introduction from speech by the biblical accents as compared to English or Greek, see Wickes, *Twenty-one Books* (1887) 35; G. ENGBERG, "Greek Ekphonic Neumes and Masoretic Accents", *Studies in Eastern Chant* 1 (1966) 41.

<sup>15</sup> Breuer, *פירוק טעמים* (1958) 156. Further problems of this sort are discussed by BREUER in *מקראות שאין להם הכרע*, *Leshonenu* 58 (1994/95) 189-99.

tion is obscure, a traditional accentuation is not likely to have resulted from error. It may well reflect an interpretation which is no longer felt to represent the simple meaning of the text which the accents typically represent. A clear example of such a process of change is known from the words אֲרָמִי אֲבָד אֲבִי in Deut 26:5. Targum Onqelos and Rashi understood the passage to mean "An Aramaean was trying to destroy my father". They treated the second word as a verb (as did the LXX, but with a different understanding of the passage). Rashbam and Ibn Ezra understood the passage to mean "A wandering Aramaean was my father" (as do most later scholars), taking the word as an attributive. The accentuation, which marks a disjunctive on 'Aramaean', the first of the three words, reflects the former view. That is, the accentuation is 'wrong' for the interpretation now usual, but it represents the interpretation accepted by the massoretic scholars, and so is the correct accentuation in the tradition.

A similar process of change is likely enough to have occurred in other cases where the motivation of the accentuation is obscure. סֵמֶל הַקִּנְאָה הַזֶּה (Ezek 8:5) can be offered as an illustration. The first word is a masculine noun, the second a feminine one. The two, which form a bound (construct) phrase, are followed by a masculine demonstrative: "image of (ms) the jealousy (fs) this one (ms)". A disjunctive is used on the first of the three words, as if the demonstrative applied to the feminine noun, instead of to the masculine one, as syntax requires. There is a parallel in סֵמֶל הַקִּנְאָה הַמִּקְנָה (Ezek 8:3), which shows the same structure save that the third word is an attributive participle, not a demonstrative. Again there is a disjunctive on the first word, and this is enough to show it unlikely that the accentuation in either case is accidental. Speculation suggests that the words הַקִּנְאָה הַמִּקְנָה in Ezek 8:3 were taken together, and understood as "jealousy which provokes jealousy", an allusion to Deut 32:21. The similar phrase in Ezek 8:5 was then understood as a reference to this. This suggestion assumes that the requirements of concord were ignored, but the treatment of feminine nouns as masculine is not particularly uncommon in the Bible (cf. Rashi on Gen 8:11).<sup>16</sup>

Such speculation is intended only to make the point that it is anachronistic to evaluate the accentuation with the criteria of modern scholarship. The ancient scholars had an excellent knowledge of the language, but they did not always understand its words in the same way that we do, whether because they lacked some fragment of knowledge now available, or because they were differently predisposed.<sup>17</sup> The medieval Jewish commentators stated the principle that interpretation should be consistent with accentuation, but, on occasion, they tacitly ignored it, as in Deut 26:5. Modern scholars naturally follow the

<sup>16</sup> The relationship between the accentuation and interpretation of the text presented in various early and medieval sources is surveyed in Kogut, המקרא בין טעמים לפראגמטיקה (1994).

<sup>17</sup> That is, they may have tended to categorize forms differently from moderns. If the argument in E. J. REVELL, "'Obed (Deut 26:5) and the Function of the Participle in MT", *Sefarad* 48 (1988) 197–205, on this point is justified, the use of a disjunctive on אֲרָמִי in Deut 26:5 is not an example of rejection of the simple meaning through preference for midrashic interpretation, as is sometimes suggested, but of a natural tendency to treat the participle as a verb where it was not clearly other, a tendency which did not persist in later times. One aspect of the argument referred to is now supported by I. BEN DAVID, חילוף שווא/צירי בבינוני, *Leshonenu* 57 (1992/93) 103–07.

same course. However, the fact that interpretation other than that suggested by the accentuation is now preferable in some contexts does not show that the traditional accentuation was wrong in the context for which it was designed. The accentuation of any passage in one particular way was not a legal requirement, but a matter of custom. The written signs were a late development. It is presumably possible that a scribal error could dominate both the written tradition and the tradition of oral presentation (probably more authoritative, at least until the ben Asher text achieved its pre-eminent position), but it would require a very surprising chain of development. The massoretic accentuation of any passage reflects the interpretation of that passage favoured by the massoretic scholars. Where its motivation is obscure, the obscurity must be accepted, since our information on these scholars is not adequate to enable us to correct it.

It is possible that the accentuation was conditioned by other factors, such as the desire to facilitate the chant by providing units of similar length. This might account for the position of the main verse division in Gen 7:13 (but cf. the different division of another compound subject representing the same group in Gen 8:18), or the division of the first half of Num 24:22. Prosodic factors no doubt affected the placing of accents in other ways, as they certainly did the choice of accent. However, such factors are likely to be relevant only where there was no need to use the accents to give prominence to particular units of content. There are also other ways in which the accents are held to convey meaning. The accent sign typically marks the position of the main word stress, and so can distinguish words identical except for stress position. Since prosodic factors can affect stress position, the possibilities are limited, but Rashi occasionally comments on a case of this sort, as in Gen 46:26-27. Accents are also credited with symbolic value, with adding some descriptive content to the word they mark. Thus the use of *shalsholet* on 'he refused', the first word in Gen 39:8, is said in one source to indicate repeated refusal. Such views are usually related only to rare accents, but a comprehensive system has recently been published.<sup>18</sup> Few scholars approach the text in this way, but it is only an advanced form of the very general view that the massoretic accents provide the text with much more than simple punctuation.

The massoretic accentuation is, then, the culmination of a long development, which may have its roots in the spoken form of 'classical' Hebrew. Evidence of this development appears sporadically from the time of the earliest biblical manuscripts on. There is no direct evidence for the use of the system we are familiar with before the appearance of manuscripts with vowel and accent signs in the ninth century, but there is good reason to believe that that system had by then been in use a long time. There was evidently a good deal of variation before the ninth century, including, perhaps, some variation in the boundaries of the verses which the accents subdivide. After that time variation diminished progressively, and typically affects only minor features. The accents divide the verses into units of content, and mark the relationship of these

<sup>18</sup> See Lavian, *משמעותם ומשמעותם* (1978). For the comment on *shalsholet* see Wickes, *Twenty-One Books* (1887) 85 n. 4.

units to each other. The early commentators, such as Saadiah, show relatively little interest in this function of the accents. Rashi was the first major commentator to make much reference to them, but, since he also valued the older interpretations, which ignored the accents, he quite often fails to attend to them. Later commentators valued the accents increasingly as a guide to interpretation, an attitude which spread to some Christian scholars in the Renaissance. This interest led to increasingly detailed description of the system, culminating in the elaboration of the detailed rules for the understanding of the hermeneutic value of the accents in the second half of the nineteenth century. Since that time, interest in the accents appears generally to have diminished as interest in the use of extra-biblical material as a basis for interpretation has grown. Nevertheless, for students of the Massoretic Text in the context for which it was produced, the accents rank with the letters and the vowel signs as one of the three bases of the holy tongue (as medieval scholars put it) on which the pillars of the Bible are built: essential to its understanding.

## 25.3. The Geonim of Babylonia as Biblical Exegetes

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